

THE LONG ROAD TO HOLLOW REACH

CENTURIES BEFORE ANY CARAVAN WILLINGLY TOOK the eastern fork, *the Long Road* was a pilgrim track maintained by the Order of the Verdant Hand. The road outlived the order; the pilgrims outlived neither, though the track still expects them. The wind through the standing stones carries a tone older than the language used to describe it. Travelers who pause too long at the crossroads find that the moss has spoken their names back to them.

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THE THREE APPROACHES

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- The **Stag Path** winds through bracken and antler-ledge.
- The **Pilgrim Steps** rise switchbacked along the gorge.
- The **Crow Road** is what is left of an old toll-line.

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A RANDOM ENCOUNTER TABLE

d8	Encounter	Notes
1	Wandering minstrel	Refuses payment, demands a story instead.
2	Boar in a snare	Setting it free triggers a forest spirit favour.
3	Bramble-knight patrol	Two of these, see stat block.
4	Lost child	Not a child. Not lost.
5	Hollow stag	Will trade an antler for a song.
6	Wretchroot druid	Run.
7	Cairn that follows	Each rest, it is closer.
8	Old toll-stone	Demands a name in payment.

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RUNNING THE LONG ROAD

The road is meant to feel like a held breath. Resist the urge to populate every clearing with combat. The land's *memory* is the antagonist; encounters are punctuation.

Players who skip the optional rests should pay an attrition tax — exhaustion, lost rations, or a dream they didn't consent to.

THE FIRST ENCOUNTER

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BRAMBLE-KNIGHT

Medium plant (formerly humanoid), lawful neutral

Armor Class 17 (thorny mail)

Hit Points 92 (14d8 + 28)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
17 (+3)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	9 (-1)	13 (+1)	8 (-1)

Saving Throws Str +6, Con +5

Skills Athletics +6, Perception +4

Damage Resistances piercing, slashing

Senses passive Perception 14

Languages Common, Sylvan

Challenge 5 (1,800 XP)

Thornbound. A creature that hits the bramble-knight with a melee attack takes 1d6 piercing damage.

Verdant Stride. Difficult terrain composed of plants does not cost the bramble-knight extra movement.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The bramble-knight makes two longsword attacks.

Longsword. Melee Weapon Attack: +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 8 (1d8 + 4) slashing damage.

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THEY LEFT THE ROAD, MY LORD, AND THE ROAD NEVER forgave them. It still has not. It still has them.

— A surviving outrider, statement to the Knight-Marshal

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THE HOLLOW STAG

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THE HOLLOW REACH ITSELF

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THE REACH AT DAWN

Mist hangs in slabs across the valley floor, slow-moving and faintly luminous. Sound carries oddly: a footstep ten feet away can sound nearer than the speaker's own breath. The brambles, dry and brown elsewhere, here are emerald and supple, as if drinking from something underneath the soil.

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HOLLOW STAG

Large fey beast, chaotic neutral

Armor Class 14

Hit Points 76 (9d10 + 27)

Speed 50 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	16 (+3)	16 (+3)	6 (-2)	14 (+2)	11 (+0)

Skills Perception +4, Stealth +5

Damage Immunities poison

Condition Immunities charmed, frightened

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 14

Languages understands Sylvan but cannot speak

Challenge 4 (1,100 XP)

Fey Step. Once per short rest, the hollow stag teleports up to 30 feet to an unoccupied space it can see.

ACTIONS

Antlers. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 13 (2d8 + 4) piercing damage. If the target is a Medium or smaller creature, it must succeed on a DC 14 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone.

PILGRIM'S MEMORY

2nd-level divination

Casting Time: 1 action

Range: Self

Components: V, S, M (a coin from a road no longer travelled)

Duration: Concentration, up to 10 minutes

You recall the names of every traveler who has shared the same path with you in the past century. You can ask the spell one yes-or-no question per minute about events that took place along this road; the spell answers truthfully but obliquely.

At Higher Levels. When you cast this spell using a spell slot of 4th level or higher, you may also recall *why* each traveler took the road, though not what they sought.

Classes: Bard, Cleric, Druid

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BENEATH THE REACH

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- A **moss-covered cairn** that hums when struck.
- A **lichgate** overgrown with thorn-ivy.
- A **spring-fed pool** whose surface returns the wrong reflection.
- A **hollow tree** wide enough to walk inside.

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THE FINAL CONFRONTATION

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VAEL'S SUCCESSOR

If your campaign already used *Vael of the Hollow* from [The Sunken Grove](#), the wretchroot druid below is her apprentice — and your party owes them both an answer.

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WRETCHROOT DRUID

Medium humanoid (human, druid), neutral evil

Armor Class 16 (hide armor + shield)

Hit Points 132 (17d8 + 51)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
11 (+0)	14 (+2)	16 (+3)	12 (+1)	19 (+4)	13 (+1)

Saving Throws Wis +8, Int +5

Skills Nature +5, Perception +8

Damage Resistances necrotic, poison

Senses darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 18

Languages Common, Druidic, Sylvan, Undercommon

Challenge 9 (5,000 XP)

Innate Spellcasting. The druid's spellcasting ability is Wisdom (spell save DC 16). She can cast each of the following at will: druidcraft, poison spray, thorn whip.

Blighted Wild Shape. As an action, the druid magically polymorphs into a corrupted beast form (CR 2 or less). Her statistics other than size are replaced; she retains her hit points and Wisdom score.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The druid makes two staff attacks.

Quarterstaff. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d8 + 1) bludgeoning damage, or 6 (1d10 + 1) bludgeoning damage if used with two hands, plus 9 (2d8) necrotic damage.

Bramble Snare (Recharge 5–6). Each creature within 15 feet of the druid must make a DC 15 Strength saving throw or be restrained by reaching brambles until the end of the druid's next turn.

LEGENDARY ACTIONS

Step of the Grove. The druid moves up to her speed without provoking opportunity attacks.

Cantrip. The druid casts one cantrip.

Withering Touch (Costs 2 Actions). One creature within 30 feet must succeed on a DC 16 Constitution saving throw or take 14 (4d6) necrotic damage and have its hit point maximum reduced by the same amount.

AFTERMATH

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HOOKS FOR FUTURE ADVENTURES

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